

Q I've seen the movies—what if my water breaks in the supermarket?

Labor is unpredictable, but you might be reassured to know that around 85 percent of women experience membrane rupture only when fully dilated, at the start of the second stage of labor. So you would be very unlucky to have a sudden supermarket incident in early labor. Moreover, membrane rupture is often just a slow trickle, so you should be able to get to the bathroom to check with no one else being the wiser. The farther down your pelvis your baby's head is, the less fluid you will lose if your water breaks. This is because the position of your baby forces most of the amniotic fluid into a sort of liquid "bubble" above his body.

That's not to say that a gush of amniotic fluid in the first stage isn't possible. If it happens in a public place, ask for help, find somewhere to sit, and call your doctor—you will need to be checked over, since your baby will no longer be protected from infection.

Q How should I time my contractions?

Time both the duration of your contractions, and the gap of time between them. Begin timing a contraction from the first moment of tightening at the top of your belly (the "fundus"); the contraction grows in strength and becomes more painful, pushing your baby downward. The tightening and pain should seem to move toward the lower part of the abdomen, and gradually ease—this "softer" part of the contraction helps to open out the lower part of your uterus and draw up your cervix. When the pain subsides to its weakest point, your contraction is over. Note how many seconds have passed. Also make a note of the time, since now you need to measure how long it is until your next contraction starts.

Q Do I need a stopwatch to time my contractions?

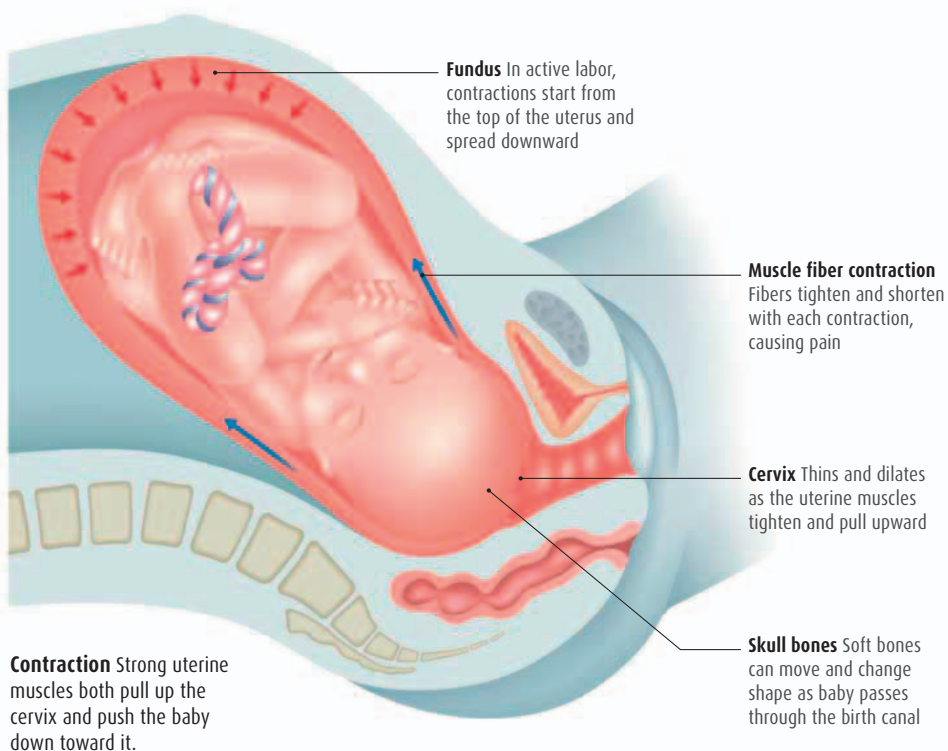
No—a simple second hand on an ordinary watch will do. If you have a smartphone, there are now some really good, free apps that will do all the work for you. Download a couple and see which you find easiest to operate; your birth partner can try them out, too.

Q What is happening when I have a contraction?

The muscles of your uterus are squeezing (or "contracting"); first to help open your cervix at the bottom, and then to push your baby downward for birth.

In early labor, or the first stage's latent phase, you can feel contractions in the lower part of your uterus. They feel similar to strong period cramps and start the process of opening your cervix. Later, in active labor, contractions become much stronger and begin from the top of the uterus (the fundus) and travel

downward. These contractions open the cervix much more quickly, and work to push your baby toward the cervix. The squeezing contractions briefly stop blood supply to the uterus; in the breaks between contractions, your baby is kept supplied with oxygen, but you may feel some residual pain.



HOW CONTRACTIONS BUILD IN FREQUENCY

At the start of labor, contractions are 15–30 seconds long, coming every 20–30 minutes. Gradually, contractions last longer, intensify, and become more frequent.

